



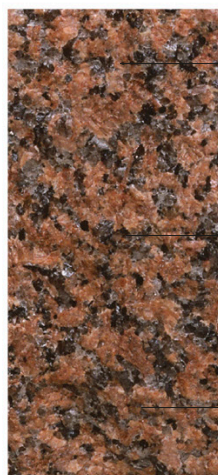
Rock salt is a mineral that is spread on roads in icy weather. It makes the ice melt.

What is a mineral?

A mineral is a solid that occurs naturally. It is made up of chemicals and has a crystal structure. Minerals are everywhere you look. We use minerals to build cars and computers, fertilize soil, and to clean our teeth.

Mineral mixtures

Granite rock is made up of different colored minerals. The black mineral is mica, the pink is feldspar, and the gray mineral is quartz.



Feldspar is used for glazing ceramics.



Mica is ground up and used in paint.

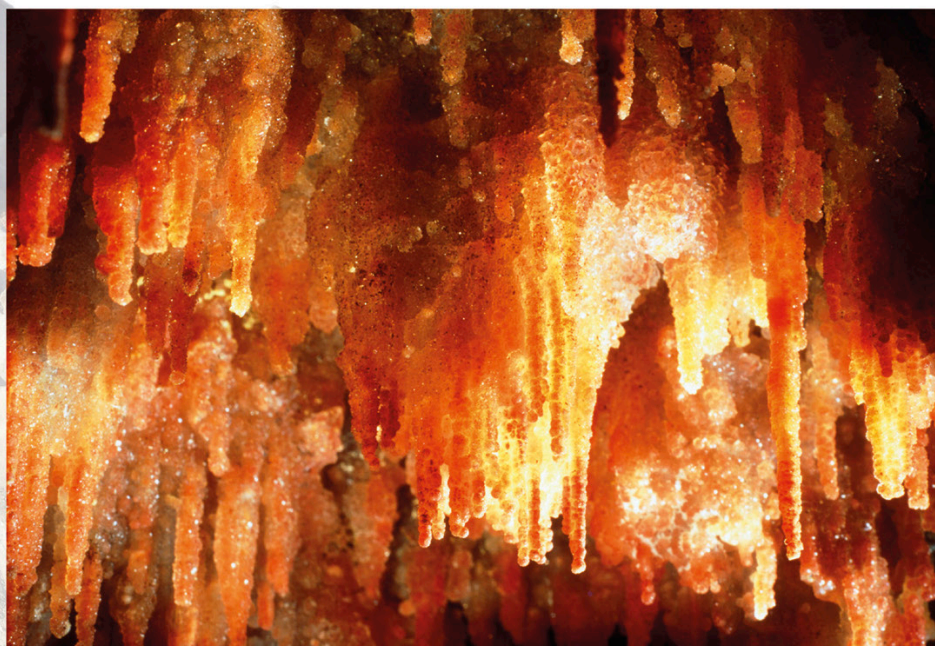


Quartz can also occur as the gemstone amethyst.



Crystals

Minerals usually form crystals. Crystals have a number of flat surfaces. The largest crystals form when minerals in magma or trapped liquids cool very slowly.



Quartz stalactites form in caves over thousands of years.

Minerals in your home

Minerals make up many common objects.



Halite is the natural form of salt, which we add to our food for flavor.



Quartz from sand is used to make the silicon chips in calculators and computers.



Kaolinite is used to make dishes. It is also used to make paper look glossy.



Illite is a clay mineral and is used in terra-cotta pots and bricks.



Mica is used to make glittery paint and nail polish.



Graphite is the lead in pencils. It is also used in bicycle brakes.

Rhodochrosite is a rose-colored gemstone used in jewelry.

